

Watershed moment: Rahul Dravid led India to its first ICC trophy in 11 years with the T20 World Cup triumph last June. K. R. DEEPAK

scenario, many teams, including RR, would have liked to retain more. The auction reflected the value of the released players, and given budget constraints, it was never realistic to bring back the same squad.

That's the reality of this league — every three years, a reset happens. It was disappointing to part ways with some players, but we made a commitment to the franchise, the players, and the fans by retaining the maximum number allowed.

Most of the players we retained have been with the franchise for years and have grown within this setup. In Sanju (Samson)'s case, it has been much longer. This felt like the right time to trust these players with the responsibility of leading the franchise forward.

Although they are young in age, they have already gained significant experience within our system. Retaining them allows us to plan for the next two cycles, depending on future rules. It's rewarding to see players who developed under our care staying on.

That's what any franchise aims for. This auction gave us the opportunity to prioritise continuity. Of course, it came at the cost of releasing some senior and experienced players, which was difficult. But these are the rules, and every team has to make similar choices.

Fans may feel disappointed, but the system ensures fairness. It also provides players and teams with a fresh start, which is an integral part of the league's evolution.

After 17 years, do you think that an auction comes at the expense of a core?

I understand the sentiments behind this because we've been through the frustration of the auction cycle — having to let players go and then rebuilding. We always try to retain our core and build around it.

But the auction system is what keeps the league highly competitive.



The ability to rebuild every three or four years ensures that no team dominates indefinitely. Any team can beat any other, and that's what makes the IPL so exciting.

The salary cap and equal purse for all teams further enhance this competitiveness. While there are valid arguments on both sides about the effectiveness of an auction, there's no clear-cut answer.

As a coach, you want to keep your core intact for as long as possible. The debate over whether the cycle should last three years or five years is always open.

The league now permits teams to retain six players, the highest ever. But a large auction every three years ensures that teams can reassess their squads and remain competitive. It's also beneficial for players.